

ELEVEN WORDS

written by

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FADE IN:

INT. RALPHS SUPERMARKET -- MOORPARK, CA -- DAY

Fluorescent light. A Tuesday. The cereal aisle, which is the loneliest aisle.

JOSH, early 40s, pushes a cart with one bad wheel. He has the posture of a man between things -- between jobs, between versions of himself. He is comparing two identical store-brand raisin brans for no reason.

He looks up.

At the far end of the aisle: LEWIS, 70s, Vietnam-era veteran, in a Members Only jacket that has outlived several presidents. A small healed scar on his upper lip. He is holding a bag of coffee and squinting at it like it owes him money.

Josh's face opens. Automatic. Genuine. He raises a hand -- Lewis sees him.

And Lewis's face does something terrible: nothing. It closes like a store. He looks at Josh the way you look at weather. Then he sets the coffee down on the wrong shelf, turns his cart around, and walks the other way.

Josh stands there, hand still half-raised, in the cereal aisle, under the fluorescent light, holding two identical raisin brans.

A long moment. The store PA plays an instrumental version of a song that used to mean something to somebody.

SUPER: "THREE MONTHS EARLIER"

CUT TO:

INT. JOSH'S MOTHER'S KITCHEN -- MOORPARK -- MORNING

A small, clean, rented kitchen. Everything in it is fifteen years old and cared for. DONNA, late 60s, Josh's mother, stands at the counter portioning pills into a

weekly organizer that is not hers.

Josh sits at the table in a T-shirt, eating toast, with the specific stillness of a man whose calendar is empty.

DONNA

You could come with me.

JOSH

Where.

DONNA

Lewis. I told you about Lewis.
Bertha's brother. I'm taking him
to the VA Thursday, they found
something on his lip.

JOSH

Something.

DONNA

A carcinoma. Squamous cell. It's
the good kind, if you get it
early, which --

(she snaps the pill
organizer shut)

-- we did not.

JOSH

Who's "we"?

DONNA

Me and Bertha. Mostly me.

(beat)

Anyway, it's a four-forty-five
departure. I could use the
company. And you're not --

She stops herself. Josh looks up. She recalibrates,
gently:

DONNA (CONT'D)

You're available.

JOSH

(returning to the toast)

I'm available.

It's not a yes. It's not a no. Donna takes it, because she knows her son, and she knows that "available" is the most he's said about himself in three weeks.

INT. JOSH'S CAR -- PRE-DAWN -- THURSDAY

4:45 AM. Dark. Josh drives, Donna in the passenger seat with a folder of Lewis's paperwork on her lap, organized with tabs. Streetlights strobe by.

JOSH

Who tabs another man's biopsy results.

DONNA

Somebody has to.

JOSH

The VA doesn't do that?

DONNA

The VA gives you a portal login and a phone number that plays Vivaldi.

They pull up outside --

EXT. BERTHA'S HOUSE -- CONTINUOUS

A nice house. Noticeably nice. Two stories, actual landscaping, a flagpole, a boat under a fitted cover in the side yard that has not touched water in years. In this neighborhood, at this hour, the house is dark except for one upstairs window.

Josh puts it in park. They wait.

They wait.

JOSH
What time did you tell her?

DONNA
Four forty-five.

JOSH
And what time is it?

DONNA
Don't do that.
They wait. Josh looks at the boat.

JOSH
Does the boat come with the
friendship or is that separate?

DONNA
Josh.
The porch light snaps on. The front door opens and BERTHA,
70s, appears -- robed, unhurried, waving with both hands
in a way that communicates enormous effort. She calls
across the lawn in a stage whisper that is louder than
talking:

BERTHA
Five minutes! He's on the toilet!
It's been a whole thing with the
toilet!
The door closes. Josh looks at the clock: 4:58.

JOSH
It's a forty-minute drive.

DONNA
It's an hour with the 405.

JOSH
So we're late.

DONNA

We're always late. Then we wait
two hours at the other end
anyway. It cancels out.

JOSH

That's not how -- okay.

He turns off the engine. They sit in the dark outside the
nice house. This is the arrangement. This has always been
the arrangement.

**INT./EXT. JOSH'S CAR -- BERTHA'S DRIVEWAY -- LATER (5:20
AM)**

The front door opens again and LEWIS comes out -- moving
carefully, dressed sharp for a medical appointment:
slacks, the Members Only jacket, a VFW cap. Bertha steers
him by the elbow like a tugboat docking a tanker,
narrating the whole way:

BERTHA

-- and his socks were wet, don't
ask me how, the socks were wet,
so that was its own production --

Lewis reaches the car, opens the back door, and gets in
with a sigh that has three wars in it. He settles. Looks
at Josh in the rearview. Sizes him up.

LEWIS

Who's this.

DONNA

My son. Josh. I told you about
Josh.

LEWIS

(fastening his seatbelt with
great care)
The one who quit his job or the
one in Texas?

JOSH

The one who quit his job.

LEWIS

(approvingly)

Good. Jobs are how they get you.

Bertha leans in the window, hand on the roof of the car,
and delivers the morning's tragedy:

BERTHA

I have been up since three-thirty
with Mother. Three-thirty. She
wanted the television on, then
she wanted it off, then she
wanted to know why it was off --

(to Donna, meaningfully)

Nobody knows what my life is.

DONNA

(with practiced warmth)

We've got him, Bertha. Go back to
bed.

BERTHA

Bed. That's funny. That's very
funny.

She pats the roof twice -- dismissed -- and walks back
toward the house. Josh watches her go in the mirror.

Josh backs out of the driveway. From the back seat:

LEWIS

There's a McDonald's on Los
Angeles Avenue that opens at
five.

JOSH

You're having surgery consult at
seven. Aren't you supposed to
fast?

LEWIS

That's for anesthesia. This is local. I looked it up.

(beat; the whole sentence again, slower, as a fact of nature)

There's a McDonald's on Los Angeles Avenue. That opens at five.

Josh looks at Donna. Donna looks out the window with the neutrality of Switzerland.

JOSH

...What do you get?

LEWIS

Two Sausage McMuffins with egg.
Large black coffee. Apple pie if they have it.

(beat)

They always have it.

INT. MCDONALD'S -- LOS ANGELES AVENUE -- 5:04 AM

Empty. Lit like an operating theater. Josh at the counter, paying. Through the window behind him we can see Lewis in the car, sitting up straight in the back seat, watching the bag's progress with the alertness of a man tracking a medevac.

INT. JOSH'S CAR -- MOVING -- THE 118 WEST -- PRE-DAWN

Lewis eats the first McMuffin in reverent silence. Then, mid-second-McMuffin, unprompted, to no question whatsoever:

LEWIS

You know what nobody wants to admit? "Street-Legal" is a top-five Dylan record.

JOSH

(checking his mirror,
changing lanes)

I don't know what that is.

A silence. Donna closes her eyes, because she knows what
Josh has just done.

LEWIS

(setting down the McMuffin)

You don't know what that is.

JOSH

I know Bob Dylan. Blowing in the
wind. The one that goes --

LEWIS

Don't. Don't do the voice.

Everybody does the voice.

(leaning forward, seatbelt
straining)

Nineteen seventy-eight. He's got
a full band, he's got the girl
singers, everybody says it's over
for him, the critics -- Rolling
Stone put a knife in that record
-- and it's got "Señor" on it.
You know "Señor"?

JOSH

I don't know "Señor."

LEWIS

(sitting back; to Donna; a
diagnosis)

He doesn't know "Señor."

DONNA

(eyes still closed)

He'll learn it.

LEWIS

(looking out the window; the
last word)
"Señor" would fix half of what's
wrong with this country.

Josh looks at him in the rearview. And despite himself --
for the first time in the movie, maybe for the first time
in months -- Josh is smiling a little.

**EXT. VA MEDICAL CENTER -- WILSHIRE BOULEVARD, WEST LOS
ANGELES -- DAWN**

The real thing: four hundred acres of it. Mission Revival
buildings from another century, palm trees, a chapel with
a bell tower, long lawns going gold in the first light --
and rising behind the old campus, the modern hospital
towers. Beautiful and bureaucratic at once, like a mission
staffed by the DMV.

Josh's car, small, moves up the long entrance drive.

INT. VA HOSPITAL -- DERMATOLOGY WAITING ROOM -- MORNING

Rows of chairs. Veterans of four wars, each with a
caretaker or alone, all in the same beige light. A TV
bolted to the wall plays a cooking show with the sound
off.

Lewis fills out a form on a clipboard. Donna, beside him,
quietly corrects the date he's written, which is off by a
year. Neither of them comments on it. It's a system.

Josh sits on Lewis's other side, useless, hands on his
knees. He looks around the room. An OLDER VETERAN in a
wheelchair by the window, alone, dozing upright. Another
VET with a walker, reading the same page of a pamphlet
over and over.

Josh gets up.

INT. VA HOSPITAL -- CANTEEN / COFFEE CART -- MOMENTS LATER

Josh buys three coffees. He didn't plan to buy three. His
hands did it.

INT. VA HOSPITAL -- DERMATOLOGY WAITING ROOM -- CONTINUOUS

Josh hands one coffee to Donna. Then he crosses the room and sets one down, gently, on the little table next to the dozing veteran in the wheelchair.

The man wakes. Looks at the coffee. Looks at Josh.

OLDER VETERAN

What's this.

JOSH

It's coffee.

OLDER VETERAN

(suspicious)

Who from?

JOSH

(shrugging; already leaving)

The Army, probably. They owe you one.

The older veteran looks at the coffee. Decides to accept the premise. Drinks.

Josh sits back down next to Lewis. He doesn't tell anyone what he just did. But watch him: something in his shoulders has come down half an inch. He looks -- and the film should let us feel this without a single line about it -- useful.

LEWIS

(not looking up from the clipboard)

You're all right, kid.

JOSH

You didn't see anything.

LEWIS

I see everything. That's my whole problem.

It's a joke and it's not a joke -- the first, lightest surfacing of the thing Lewis carries. Josh clocks it. Files it. The nurse calls:

NURSE (O.S.)

Lewis? Lewis, they're ready for you.

Lewis stands, hands Donna the clipboard, straightens the VFW cap.

LEWIS

(to Josh, deadpan, going in)
If I don't come back, the apple pie's in the car. Don't let her have it.

He goes. Donna and Josh sit side by side in the beige light.

DONNA

(quietly; not looking at him)
You bought that man a coffee.

JOSH

It's a dollar forty.

DONNA

I didn't say anything about the price.

She goes back to the paperwork. Josh looks at the TV, where a chef silently juliennes something. He is, visibly, better this morning -- at 6 AM, in a hospital waiting room, between an old woman's paperwork and a stranger's coffee -- than we have any reason to believe he is anywhere else in his life.

The film doesn't say so. The film just watches him sit there, steady.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. DONNA'S KITCHEN -- NIGHT

The kitchen table has become a research station. Donna's reading glasses. Two library books about skin cancer with those crinkly plastic covers. Josh's laptop, open to a medical journal he has to keep re-reading because it wasn't written for humans.

JOSH

(reading; slow)

Okay. Mohs. M-O-H-S. They take the tumor off in layers and check each layer under a microscope while you wait. Highest cure rate for this kind. Ninety-seven, ninety-nine percent if the margins come back clean.

DONNA

(writing it down longhand,
in a spiral notebook, in her
church handwriting)

And if they don't come back clean?

JOSH

They take another layer. Same day. You just... sit there with a hole in your lip and wait for the lab.

DONNA

How long's the wait?

JOSH

Says here an hour a layer. Could be one layer. Could be four.

DONNA
(writing)
So it's a whole day.

JOSH
It's a whole day.

Donna finishes writing. Looks at the notebook. Then at Josh.

DONNA
The lip's a bad spot. It said
that in my book too. It moves
fast on the lip.

JOSH
Then it's good we're going fast.
He says "we" without noticing he said it. Donna notices.
She doesn't touch it. She turns the page.

**INT. JOSH'S CAR -- BERTHA'S DRIVEWAY -- PRE-DAWN --
ANOTHER MORNING**

4:51 AM. Waiting again. The upstairs window is dark.
Josh's head is against the headrest. Donna's phone glows
in her lap.

The porch light. The door. Bertha, robe, both hands:

BERTHA
Ten minutes! He wants the other
jacket and I cannot find the
other jacket!

The door closes.

JOSH
(eyes shut)
He's wearing the other jacket.
He's always wearing the other
jacket. There is one jacket.

DONNA

Sleep. I'll wake you.

SERIES OF SHOTS -- THE ARRANGEMENT

-- The car at the McDonald's drive-thru window in the dark. The BAG passes through the window. From the back seat, Lewis's hands receive it like communion.

-- The 405 at 5:40 AM, brake lights to the horizon. Lewis's voice from the back, mid-thesis: "...and that's why the born-again records are better than anybody admits -- 'Every Grain of Sand,' you put that next to anything --"

-- The dermatology waiting room. Josh sets a coffee by a different wheelchair. A different veteran. Same shrug: "The Navy, probably."

-- A treatment room door closing on Lewis. Donna and Josh in hallway chairs, a two-person infrastructure.

-- The rooftop garden of the VA: raised planters, benches, a pergola, old men in gowns taking sun with IV poles. Josh alone at the rail with a coffee, looking out over four hundred acres and the 405 beyond, phone to his ear.

INT./EXT. VA HOSPITAL -- ROOFTOP GARDEN -- CONTINUOUS

Josh at the rail. He's not on a call. He's talking to his phone -- an AI assistant, the voice coming back tinny and pleasant.

JOSH

(to the phone)

Okay so -- write this down -- an app, right, for caretakers. Like family caretakers, unpaid ones. Scheduling, med lists, the VA paperwork, all of it in one place. There's millions of these people. My mom has a spiral notebook. A notebook.

AI VOICE (V.O.)

(from the phone; pleasant, infinite)

That's a great idea, Josh. Would you like me to outline a basic feature set?

JOSH

Yeah. Yeah, do that. And put it with the other ones.

AI VOICE (V.O.)

Sure. Just so you know, you have eleven other projects saved. Would you like to review them?

JOSH

(looking out at the view;
comfortable; a man with all
the time in the world)

No. Just -- keep them all
somewhere. I'm gonna get to them.

Behind him, unremarked, two patients in wheelchairs are wheeled slowly along the garden path by orderlies. The sun is nice. It's a good rooftop. He's planning a future on it.

INT. DONNA'S KITCHEN -- DAY

Donna at the table with envelopes. One of them, opened, has a letterhead we see for exactly two seconds: "NOTICE OF RENT INCREASE -- EFFECTIVE --" She reads it the whole way through, once. Then she files it in a folder -- not the Lewis folder, a thinner, sadder folder -- and puts it in a drawer, and starts making dinner.

Nobody says anything about it. This scene is fourteen seconds long.

INT. LEWIS'S APARTMENT -- DAY

A small, government-adjacent one-bedroom. Immaculate in the way of a man with military habits and no visitors. On the wall: a framed photo of a young Lewis in uniform, 1969, unsmiling. On the shelf: exactly one row of Bob Dylan CDs, alphabetized incorrectly on purpose in an order

only Lewis understands.

Donna checks his refrigerator, throws out something expired. Josh stands at the CD shelf.

JOSH

Why is "Blood on the Tracks"
first? It's B, but so is --

LEWIS

(from his chair; not
looking)

It's first because it's first.

JOSH

That's not a system.

LEWIS

It's the only system.

Josh moves down the row. Between "Desire" and "Highway 61," wedged flat, he finds it: a PINT OF VODKA, plastic, half gone.

Josh doesn't say anything. He looks at Lewis. Lewis is looking at the television, which is off.

LEWIS (CONT'D)

(to the dark TV; evenly)
Some nights it gets loud in here.

JOSH

(carefully)
The neighbors?

LEWIS

(a small, patient smile --
Josh knows better and Lewis
knows he knows)
Sure. The neighbors.

A silence. Josh holds the bottle. This is the moment a lesser movie has a speech in. This movie doesn't.

JOSH

The thing is, it makes the
neighbors louder. After. That's
the trade.

LEWIS

(still looking at the dark
TV)

Everybody wants to tell me about
the trade. I invented the trade.
I've been making the trade since
Nixon.

Beat.

LEWIS (CONT'D)

(quieter; the actual man,
briefly, all the way
visible)

Leave it there where I can see it
not being drunk. That works
better than taking it. When you
take it I just think about where
to get the next one, and then
that's ALL I think about, and
that's worse than the neighbors.

Josh considers. Then he puts the bottle back -- visible,
upright, in front of "Desire."

Lewis nods at the television.

LEWIS (CONT'D)

Put on the Newport thing. Where
he goes electric and they all
lose their minds.

JOSH

(getting the remote)

The crowd was booing because of
the sound mix. I read that.

LEWIS

(with contempt so total it
is almost love)
You "read that." Sit down. I was
ALIVE, I'll tell you what they
were booing.

Josh sits down. He stays two hours longer than the errand
required.

INT. LEWIS'S APARTMENT -- KITCHEN -- ANOTHER DAY

Donna is boxing up a week of prepared meals into Lewis's
freezer, labeled with masking tape: MON. TUES. WEDS. Josh
is fixing the hinge on a cabinet with a screwdriver he
brought from home, because last week the cabinet was "the
thing that had been clicking at night."

From the other room: the good crash. The bad crash. A
CRASH.

INT. LEWIS'S APARTMENT -- LIVING ROOM -- CONTINUOUS

Lewis is on the floor between the chair and the
television, seizing. Full tonic-clonic -- his heels
drumming the carpet, the VFW cap knocked loose, the TV
remote still in his curled hand.

DONNA

(instantly there; on her
knees; this is not her
first)

On his side -- help me get him on
his side -- don't hold him down,
just clear the --

Josh -- who has never seen this, whose whole body has gone
cold -- moves the coffee table, drops to his knees, gets
his rolled-up jacket under Lewis's head. His hands are
shaking. Donna's aren't.

DONNA (CONT'D)

(calm, clocking her watch)
Time. Look at your watch, not at
him. If it goes past five minutes
we call.

Josh looks at his watch. He does not look at Lewis. The sound design here: the drumming heels, the ticking of the actual second hand, and Donna's breathing, level, like a metronome.

The seizing slows. Stops. Lewis goes slack. A long, obscene quiet.

DONNA (CONT'D)

(hand on Lewis's chest; to
Josh, gently)

Two minutes ten. That's a regular
one. He'll come back slow and he
won't know the room. Don't quiz
him. Just say the day.

Lewis's eyes open. They find the ceiling. They find nothing.

JOSH

(as instructed; his voice
not quite level)

Hey. It's Tuesday. It's Tuesday,
Lewis.

LEWIS

(from very far away)
...Tuesday.

JOSH

Tuesday. And your show's on
tonight. The Newport thing.

Lewis breathes. His hand lets go of the remote. His eyes track slowly to Josh's face, and land, and hold on -- the way you hold on to the one fixed point in a moving room.

LEWIS

(barely)
...You're the kid who doesn't
know "Señor."

JOSH

(and it comes out before he
can stop it, half a laugh,
half something else
entirely)

Yeah. Yeah, that's me.

HOLD ON the three of them on the floor of the small
apartment: the old man coming back, the mother checking
his pulse against her watch, the son holding the rolled-up
jacket. Nobody in this shot is being paid.

**INT. JOSH'S CAR -- OUTSIDE BERTHA'S HOUSE -- DUSK -- DAYS
LATER**

Parked. Engine off. Donna in the passenger seat, phone in
her hand, gathering herself. Through the windshield: the
nice house, the flagpole, the boat.

JOSH

You don't have to do it today.

DONNA

It's been six months at the same
amount. Groceries went up. Gas
went up. And after Tuesday --
(beat; she still can't say
"the seizure" casually)
-- after Tuesday, it's not
driving. It's nursing. It's
different work now.

JOSH

How much are you asking?

DONNA

Forty more a week.

JOSH

(looking at the boat)

Forty.

DONNA

Don't look at the boat.

JOSH

I'm not looking at the boat.

He is looking at the boat. Donna dials. We stay in the car -- we only hear Donna's side, and Bertha's voice as a warm, indistinct murmur.

DONNA

(into phone; light, careful,
rehearsed all afternoon)

Bertha, hi, it's me -- no, he's fine, he's good, we did the meals today -- listen, I wanted to ask you something and I want you to know it's fine either way.

(beat)

With everything now -- the appointments, and after Tuesday -- I wondered if we could talk about the weekly amount. I was thinking forty more. That's -- yes. A week.

A pause. The murmur on the other end has stopped.

Then it starts again. Longer this time. Donna listens. And we watch Donna's face do the thing this movie is about: absorb, without flinching, something that has been said pleasantly.

DONNA (CONT'D)

(quietly)

No -- Bertha, of course not. It's not about --

(listening)

No. You're right. I know you'd never want money to come between --

(listening)

Forget I -- honestly, forget I said it. It was just a thought.

(brighter, by force)

Thursday? Four forty-five. We'll
be there.

She hangs up. Sits with the phone in her lap. Josh waits
as long as he can, which is four seconds.

JOSH
What did she say.

DONNA
She said she'd hate for a
conversation about money to
change what we have. As friends.

JOSH
That's -- hang on. That's a no?

DONNA
That's a no.

JOSH
That's not even a no. A no is an
answer. That's a -- she made the
ASKING the problem. You asked for
forty dollars and now YOU did
something.

DONNA
(putting the phone in her
purse; done)
She's tired, Josh. She's got her
mother.

JOSH
We've got HER brother!

DONNA
(with the terrible patience
of women her age)
It's fine.

JOSH

It's not --

DONNA

It's fine.

She looks out the window at the nice house. And the film holds on the two of them in the old car in the falling light, outside the house with the flagpole and the boat: the people who do the work, parked outside the house of the people who have the friendship.

Josh starts the engine. Nobody says anything on the way home.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. VA HOSPITAL -- MOHS SURGERY WAITING AREA -- MORNING

SUPER: "SURGERY DAY"

A smaller, quieter waiting room. Lewis in a gown top over his slacks, a surgical marking on his lip, the VFW cap still on because nobody had the rank to take it off him. Donna beside him with the tabbed folder. Josh across, with three coffees on a tray, one already delivered to a man in a wheelchair by the door.

A NURSE appears.

NURSE

Lewis? First layer. Should be about forty-five minutes, then an hour for the lab. You two are welcome to wait or walk the grounds.

Lewis stands. Adjusts the cap. Looks at Josh and Donna -- and for one second, under all of it, he's a man walking into a room to have a piece of his face removed.

LEWIS

(to Josh; deadpan; steady as
a handshake)

"Señor." Track four. If they take
too much of the lip, I'm gonna
need you to know the words.

JOSH

Track four. I got it.

LEWIS

(going; over his shoulder,
to the nurse,
conversationally)

You know Dylan played for the
Pope? Ninety-seven. The Pope. And
people say he sold out in
SEVENTY-eight --

The door closes on the rest of the lecture. Donna exhales
for the first time in an hour.

EXT. VA HOSPITAL -- ROOFTOP GARDEN -- LATE MORNING

Josh at the rail again. The whole campus below: the
chapel, the lawns, the palms, the parking structures. He
has the phone out. The AI voice, pleasant, eternal.

JOSH

(to the phone)

-- okay, and the twelfth one.
Write this one down for real. The
caretaker app, but the wedge is
the VA specifically. The portal's
unusable, the phone line's
Vivaldi, there's four hundred
acres here and no map that works.
You build the layer on top.
Veterans' families would --

AI VOICE (V.O.)

I've saved that with your other
projects. By the way -- you asked

me to remind you when the first
of the month was coming up. It's
this Friday.

A beat. Josh looks at the phone.

JOSH

Yeah. No. I know.

(beat)

Skip that reminder going forward.

AI VOICE (V.O.)

Done. Would you like to keep
working on the app idea?

JOSH

(looking out at the view;
quieter)

Yeah. Let's keep working on the
app idea.

The wind moves the pergola shade. Below him, tiny, an
orderly wheels a patient along a path between
two-hundred-year-old lawns. Josh talks softly to his phone
about the future, on a roof, in the sun.

The film does not cut to the rent-increase letter in the
drawer at home. It doesn't have to. We remember it. That's
the whole trick of this scene: he's the only one on the
roof who doesn't see the ground.

INT. VA HOSPITAL -- MOHS WAITING AREA -- AFTERNOON

The nurse, back again. Donna stands. Josh stands.

NURSE

Margins are clean. First layer
got all of it.

DONNA

(one hand finding the back
of a chair)

Clean.

NURSE

Clean. He's getting stitched now.
He'll look like he went a round
or two, and the lip'll be numb
through dinner, but --

(consulting the chart; the
plainest sentence in the
movie)

-- he's cancer-free.

The nurse leaves. Donna sits back down, then immediately stands again, then sits, and laughs at herself once, wetly, and dabs her eye with a knuckle, and gets out the folder, because there will be discharge paperwork, and someone has to tab it.

Josh just stands there. Cancer-free. They did that. A retired homemaker with a spiral notebook and an unemployed guy with a bad sleep schedule -- that's the team that did that.

INT. JOSH'S CAR -- MOVING -- THE 405 NORTH -- DUSK

Lewis in the back, lip bandaged, gloriously alive, held together with stitches and floating pleasantly on local anesthetic. A McDonald's bag, already acquired, on his lap. He can't really eat yet. He holds the bag anyway. It's not about the food.

LEWIS

(articulating around the
numb lip, undefeated)

Two Sausage McMuffins with egg.
For tomorrow. Breakfast of
champions.

JOSH

The doctor said soft foods.

LEWIS

The McMuffin IS a soft food. What
do you think it is, a brisket?

DONNA

(without turning around)
He can have the egg.

LEWIS
(leaning back; closing his
eyes; the anesthetic and the
relief and the freeway hum
all at once)
"Señor, señor, do you know where
we're headin'..."
(half-singing, terribly,
through a numb lip)
"...Lincoln County Road or
Armageddon..."

He hums the rest. He doesn't know all the words either, it
turns out. Josh drives, and listens, and files this away
with the things he plans on keeping.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. BERTHA'S HOUSE -- PRE-DAWN -- WEEKS LATER

6:30 AM. Follow-up appointment day -- suture check,
pathology review. The house is dark. The car idles at the
curb. It is raining a little, that thin valley rain that
doesn't commit.

INT. JOSH'S CAR -- CONTINUOUS

Josh looks bad this morning. Not movie-bad -- real bad:
gray, puffy, the specific wreckage of a man who watched
the ceiling till 4 and got up at 5. Donna, in the
passenger seat, is on the phone with Bertha. The phone
lies face-up on the center console between them, on
speaker, because Donna's hands are busy with the folder.

BERTHA (V.O.)

(from the console;
mid-tragedy)
-- because Mother had one of her
nights, you don't know what her
nights are, nobody knows what her
nights are -- so Lewis is not
dressed, and I said to him,
Lewis, they cannot take you at
eight if you will not put on the
pants --

DONNA
(rummaging the folder)
It's fine, Bertha. We're outside
whenever he's ready.

BERTHA (V.O.)
Fifteen minutes. Twenty at the
outside. It's the pants and then
it's the pills and then honest to
God I need to sit down for one
minute before --

The murmur continues, becomes weather. Donna finds the
form she was looking for. Sets the folder on the dash. The
phone stays on the console. Face up. Connected.

The rain ticks on the roof. Josh's eyes are closed. When
he speaks, it's barely a voice -- a low, cooked,
6:30-in-the-morning mutter, meant to travel eighteen
inches and die:

JOSH
I swear to God, if the old lady
would just die already --

Beat. Eyes still closed.

JOSH (CONT'D)
-- we could all sleep in.

Eleven words, and then the tag. He doesn't even smile at
his own joke. It's not really a joke; it's a pressure
valve. Donna, half-listening, gives him the reflexive
backhand swat on the arm that mothers give -- the "don't

say that" swat, one part reprimand, three parts agreement.

DONNA

(under her breath)

Josh.

And that's it. That's the whole event. The scene does not underline anything. No push-in on the phone. No cut to the other end of the line. No sting. The phone just sits there on the console with the call timer running -- 4:51... 4:52... 4:53 -- the way it has sat there a hundred mornings.

After a moment, from the console:

BERTHA (V.O.)

(exactly the same pleasant
register as before; maybe --
MAYBE -- a half-second late)

...He's coming out now. He found
the pants.

The call ends. The screen goes home-screen. Donna picks up the phone, drops it in her purse.

The porch light comes on. Lewis comes out under a golf umbrella that Bertha holds over him for exactly the six feet the porch roof doesn't cover. He gets in the back. The bandage is off; the lip has a neat pink scar.

LEWIS

(settling in; nodding at the
rain)

Good day for it. Dylan wrote
"Buckets of Rain" about a day
like this. Last track on "Blood
on the Tracks." People sleep on
that track.

JOSH

(pulling out; the tiredness
lifting a little, on
schedule, the way it always
does when Lewis starts up)

Nobody sleeps on it. You bring it
up every time it rains.

LEWIS

Because it KEEPS BEING RIGHT.

They drive off. In the side mirror: Bertha on the porch,
umbrella still up under the porch roof, watching the car
go.

Held one beat longer than we've ever held on her.

Nothing in her face you could name in court.

INT. VA HOSPITAL -- DERMATOLOGY -- EXAM ROOM -- MORNING

A DOCTOR examines Lewis's lip with a lighted magnifier.

DOCTOR

That's beautiful healing.
Pathology's all clear. Whoever
caught this early and got you in
-- that's what saved the lip.
Frankly, could've saved more than
the lip.

LEWIS

(pointing a thumb sideways
at Josh and Donna,
matter-of-fact, like citing
a source)

Them. They did the research at
the kitchen table. She's got a
notebook.

The doctor looks at Donna and Josh -- a civilian woman
with a tabbed folder and a tired man holding a tray of
coffees -- and gives them the small nod medical
professionals reserve for the competent.

DOCTOR

Good team.

LEWIS

(putting his cap back on;
closing the subject)
The best in the business.

Josh looks at the floor, embarrassed, pleased, fully
alive. Remember this frame. It's the last one of its kind.

INT. RALPHS SUPERMARKET -- DAY -- WEEKS LATER

Not the cold open -- earlier than that, the first one.
Josh with a basket: bread, eggs, the cheap coffee. He
rounds the endcap into the cereal aisle and there's Lewis,
with Bertha three steps behind pushing the cart.

JOSH
(lighting up; automatic)
Hey! Look who's ambulatory.

Lewis looks at him.

And it's wrong. It's small, but it's wrong. A hesitation
where there's never been one. Lewis's eyes go to Bertha --
a checking look, the look of a man consulting an authority
-- then back to Josh. And what lands on his face isn't
anger. It's worse. It's hurt. Guarded, coached, secondhand
hurt.

LEWIS
(quietly; civil; from a new
distance)
Hey.

That's all. One syllable, where there used to be a Dylan
lecture. Bertha steers the cart, pleasantly, unhurriedly,
down the aisle.

BERTHA
(passing Josh; warm as ever;
absolutely nothing in it you
could prove)
Tell your mother I said hello.

They go. Josh stands in the aisle with his basket.

JOSH

(calling after, before he
can stop himself)
Lewis -- track four, right? I
learned it. The words.

Lewis's step catches. Half a beat. A hitch you'd need slow
motion to swear to.

He doesn't turn around.

They round the corner and are gone, and the store PA plays
on, and Josh stands there doing the math that will not
resolve: carrying the one, getting nothing, carrying it
again.

INT. DONNA'S KITCHEN -- NIGHT

Josh paces the small kitchen. Donna sits at the table,
very still, in front of a cup of tea she isn't drinking.

JOSH
Something got said. Something got
said TO him, about US, because
that man looked at me like I
keyed his car, and I have done
nothing -- Ma, I have done
nothing but drive that man to Los
Angeles at four in the morning
for six months --

DONNA
(quiet)
I know.

JOSH
So what is it? Did she -- was it
the money thing? The forty
dollars? Is this the forty
dollars?

DONNA
I don't know.

JOSH

Did something happen with --
 (and here it is; watch him
 almost reach it)
-- was it something I --

He stops pacing. Somewhere in the sediment of a hundred identical gray mornings, something shifts. The rain. The console. The timer running.

His face changes -- not to certainty. To the exact absence of certainty. Which is so much worse.

JOSH (CONT'D)
 (slowly)
The morning with the rain. The follow-up. Was she still on the phone when I --

DONNA
 (a long pause; she's done this math already, days ago, alone)
The call was still connected. I don't know if she was still on the line. Sometimes she puts the phone down to help him with the pants.

JOSH
"Sometimes."

DONNA
Sometimes.

JOSH
So she either heard me wish her mother dead, or she was in another room finding pants, and we will never --
 (he sits down across from her; lands hard)
-- there's no way to ever know.

DONNA
(looking at the tea)
No.

JOSH
And I can't apologize, because if
she DIDN'T hear it, the apology
IS the confession. I'd be walking
a signed statement over to her
house.

DONNA
(gently; the whole Coen
brothers movie in four
words)
So we act normal.

JOSH
(staring at her)
Normal.

DONNA
Thursday's the follow-up on his
blood pressure. Four forty-five.
We act normal.

A long silence in the little kitchen. The refrigerator
hums. Josh puts his face in his hands. Through his
fingers, muffled, with no self-pity -- just genuine, awful
wonder at the machinery of it:

JOSH
Eleven words. I did everything
right for six months and I'm
going to lose on eleven words
nobody will even ACCUSE me of.

Donna reaches over and pats his arm -- the same arm, the
same spot she swatted in the car. Neither of them notices
the symmetry. The audience does.

EXT. BERTHA'S HOUSE -- PRE-DAWN -- THURSDAY

The car at the curb. 4:45 exactly. The porch light comes on -- immediately, for the first time in the history of the arrangement. The door opens and Lewis comes out ALONE, dressed, ready, on time.

No Bertha. No stage whisper. No tragedy of the socks. He gets in the back. Quietly.

LEWIS

Morning.

DONNA

(carefully)

Morning, Lewis. You're bright and early.

LEWIS

(fastening the seatbelt; not meeting anyone's eyes in the mirror)

Bertha got me up. She's been getting me up.

Josh pulls out. Silence in the car. No Dylan. The 118 in the dark.

Josh watches the rearview more than the road. Then, an offering, into the quiet:

JOSH

There's that McDonald's on Los Angeles Avenue. Opens at five.

A pause.

LEWIS

(looking out the window)

I ate.

Two words. The whole cold war in two words. Donna closes her eyes.

The car drives on in the dark, all three of them acting normal, no one saying anything, the space between the front seat and the back seat now approximately four

hundred acres across.

INT. VA HOSPITAL -- WAITING ROOM -- MORNING

Lewis checks in at the desk -- he takes the clipboard himself this time, waves off Donna's folder with a polite, terrible little gesture: got it.

Josh stands at the coffee cart. Buys three coffees on autopilot. Looks at the third cup.

There's a veteran in a wheelchair by the window, like always. Different man, same window. Josh carries the coffee over, sets it down.

WHEELCHAIR VETERAN

What's this?

JOSH

Coffee.

WHEELCHAIR VETERAN

Who from?

JOSH

(flat; the bit's still there
but the music's gone out of
it)

Just take it. It's coffee.

The veteran takes it. Josh walks back to his seat. And here's the scene the whole movie has been building in secret: NOTHING happens. No warmth in the chest. No half-inch drop of the shoulders. He checks his phone. He drinks his own coffee. It's a beverage.

He looks across the waiting room at Lewis, who is filling out his own clipboard, getting the date wrong by a year with nobody to catch it.

Josh looks back at his phone.

HOLD on him: a man doing a kind thing and feeling nothing, which is somehow the saddest shot in a movie that includes cancer.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. DONNA'S KITCHEN -- DAY -- WEEKS LATER

Donna at the table with her phone. She dials. We hear it ring. And ring. Then Bertha's voicemail -- chipper, recorded years ago in better times:

BERTHA (V.O.)

(recording)

You've reached Bertha! Leave a message and God bless!

DONNA

(after the beep; light; the lightness costing her)

Bertha, hi, it's me. Just checking on Thursday -- whether you need us for the podiatry thing. Call me back.

She hangs up. Looks at the phone.

Off her look: this is not the first unreturned message. This is somewhere in the teens.

INT. DONNA'S KITCHEN -- ANOTHER DAY

Donna on the phone, mid-call, standing very still by the window.

DONNA

(into phone)

No -- Carol, I understand, I just -- who's taking him Thursday, then?

(listening)

A service. She hired a service.

(listening; and here it comes, from a friend of a

friend, thirdhand, the way
these things always arrive)
She said WHAT?

INT. DONNA'S KITCHEN -- CONTINUOUS -- MOMENTS LATER

Josh, summoned from the other room, leans on the doorframe. Donna sits at the table, phone face-down in front of her like something that died.

DONNA

Carol heard it from Bertha's
niece. At the graduation party.
(beat)

The story is: we hated them. Her
and Lewis and their mother. All
along. That's why we "stopped
coming around."

JOSH

We stopped --
(he has to walk a small
circle)
-- SHE stopped. She stopped
answering the PHONE. There's a
voicemail box somewhere with
nineteen messages from you in it,
offering to drive her brother to
a podiatrist.

DONNA

That's the story.

JOSH

The story is we hated them. Six
months of four-A.M. mornings
because of all the hate. I did
his cancer research out of spite.
You made twenty-one freezer meals
with masking-tape labels out of
hate.

DONNA

(evenly)

Nobody at that party is going to
check.

And that's the line that stops him. Because she's right,
and because of how she says it: without surprise. Josh
looks at his mother -- at a woman who has known since long
before the phone call which way stories travel between
houses like Bertha's and kitchens like this one -- and
understands that she was braced for some version of this
from the beginning. It was never going to end with a
thank-you card.

JOSH

(quietly)

You knew she'd do something like
this.

DONNA

(standing; collecting the
tea cup; done with the
subject in the way that
means it will never be done)

I knew we weren't friends. I
hoped I was wrong.

(at the sink, back to him,
almost to herself)

The raise thing told me. You
don't say "it would affect our
friendship" about forty dollars
unless the friendship was always
about something else.

She washes the cup. That's the eulogy.

EXT. RALPHS SUPERMARKET -- PARKING LOT -- DAY

And now the movie catches up to itself.

Josh gets out of his car with the reusable bags. Walks
toward the entrance. Automatic doors.

INT. RALPHS SUPERMARKET -- THE CEREAL AISLE -- CONTINUOUS

The scene from the cold open, replayed exactly -- same coverage, same fluorescent hum, same instrumental on the PA. Josh with the two identical raisin brans. He looks up. Lewis at the end of the aisle with the coffee bag.

But this time the film stays on it past the cut we made before.

Lewis sets the coffee on the wrong shelf. Turns the cart. Walks away.

And Josh -- instead of standing frozen -- puts down the raisin bran and follows.

INT. RALPHS -- FROZEN AISLE -- CONTINUOUS

Lewis moving down the freezer cases. Josh comes around the endcap ahead of him and stops -- not blocking, just present, ten feet away, hands visible, the way you'd approach anything wounded.

JOSH

Lewis.

LEWIS

(stopping; looking at a
freezer door full of
waffles)

I got nothing to say to you.

JOSH

Then just listen for eleven
seconds. That's all I'm asking.
Eleven seconds.

Lewis doesn't leave. Which is the most he can offer, and both of them know it.

JOSH (CONT'D)

Whatever you were told -- and I
notice nobody will say it out
loud, not to me, not once --
whatever it was: I was there.
Four forty-five, every morning,
six months. That was real. The

McMuffins were real. Track four
is real -- I know every word now,
I know the live version's better,
I know the Rolling Stone review
was a hit job. That was me.
Whatever the story is now -- the
guy in the story isn't the guy
who drove the car.

A long silence. Freezer hum. Lewis looks at the waffles.
And when he finally speaks, it's not anger -- it's the
thing under Lewis, surfacing, the way it always threatened
to:

LEWIS

(low)

You know what I got, kid? I got
one sister. One. Everybody else
is gone or in the ground. And
when it gets loud at night -- you
remember about loud --

(Josh nods)

-- she's what's left. So when it
comes down to her version or your
version...

(he finally looks at Josh;
and it's terrible, because
there's still affection in
it, sealed behind glass)

...I can't afford your version.
You understand? It's not about
true. I can't AFFORD it.

Beat.

LEWIS (CONT'D)

(turning the cart; final;
quiet)

You were good to me. I know that
part. Both things are just gonna
have to be true.

He goes. Josh stands in the frozen aisle among the waffles
and the freezer hum, having just lost the argument to the
only answer that has no counter: a paranoid man performing

the sanest math of his life.

INT. JOSH'S CAR -- RALPHS PARKING LOT -- CONTINUOUS

Josh sits behind the wheel. Groceries in the passenger seat. He doesn't start the car.

He takes out his phone. Thumb hovers. Then, to the AI, because it's 2 PM on a Tuesday and there is no one else to say it to:

JOSH

(to the phone)

Hey. Delete the reminder about Lewis's podiatry thing Thursday.

AI VOICE (V.O.)

Done. You also have eleven saved project ideas -- you asked me to remind you to review them this week.

JOSH

(looking out the windshield)

Yeah. What are they.

AI VOICE (V.O.)

A caretaker scheduling app. A VA navigation layer. A meal-prep service for--

JOSH

(listening to the list the way you'd listen to a stranger's eulogy)

Stop.

(beat)

They're all the same idea, aren't they.

AI VOICE (V.O.)

There is significant thematic overlap. Would you like me to consolidate them?

Josh laughs -- once, genuinely, at himself, at the machine's phrasing, at "significant thematic overlap" as the description of his entire soul.

JOSH

No. Leave them.

He starts the car. And here -- quietly, without music -- the realization the whole movie owes us, delivered not as a speech but as a man talking half to a phone and half to a windshield:

JOSH (CONT'D)

It was never about the apps.

(beat)

Six months I told everybody I was helping my mom. Helping Lewis. Being a good guy.

(beat)

I was there because it was the only place I felt like a person. He needed the ride. I needed the four forty-five.

(beat; and this is the important part -- no guilt in it; just the plain fact, examined in daylight)

Both things are just gonna have to be true.

Lewis's own words, handed back. He puts the car in reverse.

INT. VA MEDICAL CENTER -- VOLUNTEER SERVICES OFFICE -- DAY

A small office. A VOLUNTEER COORDINATOR, 50s, unbeatable, behind a desk with a bowl of hard candy.

COORDINATOR

DAV has a volunteer driver network -- vans and personal

vehicles. We're always short.
It's early mornings, mostly. Real
early. Guys come from Lancaster,
Ventura, all over, no other way
to get here.

JOSH

Early's fine. Early's kind of my
thing.

COORDINATOR

(sliding a form across)
Background check, TB test,
defensive driving cert. Takes
about three weeks. Most people
fill this out and I never see
them again.

JOSH

(already writing)
You'll see me.

COORDINATOR

(watching him fill it out;
conversational)
Whose name goes there is
emergency contact.

JOSH

(writing it)
My mother.

COORDINATOR

She drive too?

JOSH

(beat; a small smile at the
form)
Better than me.

**EXT. A DIFFERENT MODEST HOUSE -- SIMI VALLEY -- PRE-DAWN
-- WEEKS LATER**

4:45 AM. Dark street. Josh's car idles at the curb of a small stucco house with a wheelchair ramp. The porch light is already on.

The door opens and HECTOR, 70s, Army veteran, rolls himself out and down the ramp with practiced violence, waving off help before any is offered.

HECTOR
(getting himself into the
front seat, dismantling into
the car piece by piece)
You're early.

JOSH
You were earlier. Light was on.

HECTOR
I don't sleep. Sleeping's how
they get you.

JOSH
(pulling out; deadpan)
I heard that about jobs, too.

INT. JOSH'S CAR -- MOVING -- THE 118 WEST -- PRE-DAWN

The old road. The old dark. Hector fiddles with the radio, lands on static, turns it off.

HECTOR
Dialysis, they put you in the
chair four hours. You just sit
there. You know what I do? I name
state capitals. All fifty. Then
backwards.

JOSH
Backwards alphabetically or
backwards like reversed spelling?

HECTOR
(looking at him with new
respect)
...Both. Nobody ever asks that.

They drive. Then Josh, eyes on the road, casual, a man
setting down a load so gently it makes no sound:

JOSH
There's a McDonald's up here on
the left. Opens at five.

HECTOR
I'm not supposed to have the
sodium.

JOSH
Coffee's not sodium.

HECTOR
(considering; the eternal
negotiation)
...They got the apple pie this
early?

JOSH
(and the answer comes out of
him from somewhere deep and
healed and permanent)
They always have it.

INT. VA HOSPITAL -- DIALYSIS WAITING AREA -- MORNING

Hector's been taken back. Josh, alone, at the coffee cart.
He buys two coffees. Carries one across the waiting room
to a WOMAN VETERAN, 60s, in a wheelchair by the window,
asleep sitting up.

He sets it down softly on the table beside her. She stirs.
Looks at the coffee. Looks at him.

WOMAN VETERAN

What's this?

JOSH

Coffee.

WOMAN VETERAN

Who from?

JOSH

(already walking away; over
his shoulder; the old shrug,
alive again)

The Marines, probably. They owe
you one.

WOMAN VETERAN

(calling after him)

I was Air Force!

JOSH

(not turning around)

Then they REALLY owe you one.

He sits down by the window with his own coffee. And there it is -- small, unannounced, absolutely real: the shoulders come down half an inch. The thing works again. Not because anyone forgave him. Not because the record got corrected -- it never will; somewhere across town there is a graduation party where he hates people, forever. It works because he finally knows what it is and does it anyway, with the meter running and no story attached.

Out the window: the four hundred acres. The chapel. The palms. Somewhere on the far side of all that lawn is a rooftop garden where a man once planned twelve futures.

Josh takes out his phone. Looks at it. Puts it back in his pocket.

He drinks his coffee and waits for Hector, which is the whole job, and enough.

SUPER, SMALL, OVER THE LAST SHOT: "The DAV Transportation Network is staffed entirely by volunteers. They are always

short of drivers."

FADE OUT.

THE END